

# RISK vs. REWARD – FAQs and Development Notes

Welcome to RISK vs. REWARD, where confidence is as important as knowledge.

These FAQs explore the mechanics, strategy, psychology, and audience appeal behind the format, providing a deeper look at what makes RISK vs. REWARD a distinctive television experience.

## GENERAL GAMEPLAY

### Why 12 questions?

Twelve questions create a complete dramatic arc. Early rounds allow contestants to build confidence and establish their strategy. The middle rounds test adaptability and risk management, while the final rounds deliver increasingly consequential decisions with the potential for a million-dollar prize.

**Development Insight:** The 12-question structure was designed to balance pacing, strategy, and suspense while giving every contestant a complete progression from the opening decision to the final question.

### How does the RISK/REWARD Slider work?

After seeing the question and its four possible answers, contestants adjust the RISK/REWARD Slider to reflect how confident they are in their choice. The slider determines the potential reward for a correct answer and the potential loss for an incorrect one.

As contestants move the slider, the potential outcomes for the current question and their best- and worst-case final totals update in real time. They then select their answer and lock in both decisions.

Higher risk creates greater potential rewards, but also greater potential losses. Even the most cautious setting involves some risk.

**Development Insight:** The slider gives contestants meaningful control over their own outcomes. Because the decision is made after the question and answers are revealed, the game tests both knowledge and the ability to assess confidence under pressure.

**RISK vs. REWARD**

Question: 1 Category: Landmarks

If you are facing the Mount Rushmore National Memorial, which President is shown on the far right side?

- ☐ A) Thomas Jefferson
- ☐ B) Theodore Roosevelt
- ☐ C) Abraham Lincoln
- ☐ D) George Washington

-\$272.47 RISK REWARD \$329.84

Countdown: 86

| If you miss...         |              |
|------------------------|--------------|
| You now have:          | \$533.67     |
| Minus RISK:            | \$272.47     |
| You would have:        | \$261.20     |
| <hr/>                  |              |
| The Least You Can Win: | \$0.01       |
| The Most You Can Win:  | \$251,178.56 |

| If you are correct...  |              |
|------------------------|--------------|
| You now have:          | \$533.67     |
| Plus REWARD:           | \$329.84     |
| You would have:        | \$863.51     |
| <hr/>                  |              |
| The Least You Can Win: | \$0.04       |
| The Most You Can Win:  | \$830,362.85 |

Lock in Answer

## Why show the best- and worst-case trajectories?

Contestants can see how each decision affects both the current question and the possibilities that remain in the game.

The best-case trajectory shows the highest possible finish if the contestant answers every remaining question correctly. The worst-case trajectory shows the lowest possible finish if the remaining answers are incorrect, based on the decisions made.

A contestant pursuing the million-dollar prize can watch that possibility remain—or diminish—as decisions unfold.

**Development Insight:** The trajectory display transforms the underlying mathematics into visible drama. Contestants and viewers can understand the consequences of a decision immediately, without having to calculate the long-term impact themselves.

## Can a contestant recover from a wrong answer?

Yes. An incorrect answer does not automatically end a contestant's game. The impact depends on the risk level chosen for that question, and subsequent decisions can create opportunities to recover.

Knowledge, effective risk management, and accurate confidence assessment all play a role in determining how far a contestant can go.

**Development Insight:** The format allows for comebacks while preserving the consequences of mistakes. A contestant's response to a setback can become just as revealing as the decision that caused it.

## Why can't contestants walk away?

There is no walk-away option. Contestants must play all 12 questions and accept the consequences of their decisions.

Removing the option to quit reinforces the show's central theme: contestants must commit to their choices and manage their confidence through the entire game.

**Development Insight:** The format maintains pressure from beginning to end, creating a complete game arc and ensuring that every contestant faces the same fundamental challenge: how much to risk on being right.

## What happens if time runs out?

If time expires, the contestant's current answer and slider position are automatically locked in.

This keeps the game moving and ensures that contestants must make decisions under pressure rather than deliberate indefinitely.

**Development Insight:** Time pressure adds another layer to the decision-making process while keeping contestants actively involved throughout the game.

## **What is the tone of the show?**

RISK vs. REWARD balances high-stakes tension with humor and personality.

Contestants experience genuine pressure, while the host guides viewers through the knowledge, strategy, and psychology behind each decision. Moments of triumph, second-guessing, unexpected confidence, and costly mistakes all contribute to the entertainment.

**Development Insight:** The format is designed to showcase contestant personalities as much as trivia knowledge, creating relatable, surprising, and memorable television moments.

## **Is the format adaptable?**

Yes. The core structure supports multiple variations, including:

- **Standard One-Hour Format:** Two contestants each play a complete, independent 12-question game.
- **Half-Hour Syndicated Format:** One contestant plays a complete game in each half-hour episode.
- **Couples Edition:** Partners work together to make category, answer, and slider decisions.
- **Special Event Episodes:** The format can accommodate themed and other special programming.

International adaptations can also adjust questions, prize levels, and presentation to suit local markets.

**Development Insight:** The format was designed to preserve its central gameplay and psychological tension while allowing flexibility in episode length, audience, and market.

# **AUDIENCE ENGAGEMENT & REPLAYABILITY**

## **How does the viewing experience keep audiences engaged?**

Every question creates a second game at home.

Viewers naturally ask themselves not only, "Do I know the answer?" but also, "How much would I risk on being right?"

Because contestants must express their confidence before the answer is revealed, viewers can make their own decisions and compare them with the contestant's choices.

The audience is not simply waiting to see whether an answer is correct. It is watching a decision unfold, knowing that the amount at stake was the contestant's choice.

**Development Insight:** The combination of trivia, visible consequences, and confidence-based decisions creates audience participation and emotional investment beyond simply knowing the correct answer.

### **Does the format encourage repeat play?**

Yes. Different contestants bring different knowledge, personalities, and approaches to risk.

Two equally knowledgeable contestants can finish with dramatically different outcomes based on how they manage confidence and risk. Even the same contestant may approach a question differently depending on the current score, the question itself, and the remaining opportunities.

Special episodes, returning-player events, and themed games can further expand replayability.

**Development Insight:** The interaction between knowledge and individual decision-making means that the same basic rules can produce a wide variety of games and outcomes.

### **Would companion experiences work?**

Interactive companion experiences could allow audiences to answer questions, adjust their own virtual sliders, predict contestant decisions, and compare strategies while watching the broadcast.

The existing interactive prototype demonstrates how players can select categories, answer questions, and adjust the RISK/REWARD Slider while potential outcomes update in real time.

Any companion experience could be developed separately from the television format, allowing the show to retain its focus on contestants making consequential decisions.

**Development Insight:** Interactive participation offers opportunities to extend audience engagement beyond the broadcast and explore additional digital experiences.

### **What is the average contestant payout?**

Simulation testing has been used to examine prize distributions, average and median outcomes, and the frequency of different payout levels under the game's scoring structure.

The results indicate a range of outcomes, from modest prizes to substantial paydays, with the million-dollar prize representing an exceptional result requiring a perfect game at maximum risk.

The format also allows producers to evaluate adjustments to question difficulty and prize structures as part of development and budget planning.

**Development Insight:** The prize structure was designed to balance meaningful contestant stakes, the possibility of a major win, and the consequences of risk-taking. Simulation provides a way to evaluate those trade-offs before production.

## **PSYCHOLOGICAL STRATEGY & PLAYER PROFILES**

## What kinds of contestants make for great television?

RISK vs. REWARD can showcase a wide range of personalities.

Some contestants rely heavily on knowledge and careful strategy. Others are more intuitive, aggressive, cautious, or emotionally expressive when making decisions under pressure.

Relatable contestants can generate a strong connection with viewers because audiences can imagine themselves facing the same questions and choices.

The contrast between two independent contestants in the standard one-hour format creates opportunities to see different approaches to the same fundamental challenge.

**Development Insight:** The format highlights different approaches to confidence and decision-making rather than requiring contestants to fit a single personality or playing style.

## What strategies tend to produce the strongest results?

Successful play involves balancing knowledge, confidence, and risk. Useful strategic considerations include:

- Building confidence without becoming reckless.
- Staying consistent after setbacks rather than overreacting.
- Avoiding emotional overcorrections following a correct or incorrect answer.
- Managing risk in relation to the current score and remaining questions.
- Accurately assessing what one knows—and what one does not know.

There is a fundamental trade-off: conservative decisions can protect a contestant's existing total but may reduce the maximum possible finish. Aggressive decisions create greater potential rewards while exposing the contestant to greater losses.

**Development Insight:** The format rewards accurate confidence calibration, not simply the willingness to take the biggest risks. Knowledge matters, but contestants must also decide how much that knowledge is worth risking.

## How does risk-taking behavior vary among contestants?

Contestants approach risk differently. Some naturally embrace uncertainty, while others prefer measured, conservative play.

A contestant's strategy may also change during the game. An early success can encourage greater confidence, while a costly mistake may lead to more cautious decisions—or an attempt to recover lost ground.

Personal experiences and individual approaches to uncertainty can influence how contestants respond to major decisions.

**Development Insight:** These differences create a variety of gameplay styles and give the host opportunities to explore contestants' reasoning, reactions, and changing confidence throughout the game.

## EXPANSION POTENTIAL

### Can the show support themed episodes?

Yes. Potential themes include:

- Sports Edition
- History & Culture
- Pop Culture Spotlight
- Holiday Specials
- Tournament Events

The category and question content can be tailored to specific audiences while preserving the core gameplay and the RISK/REWARD Slider.

**Development Insight:** The flexible question structure offers opportunities for themed programming without changing the central format.

### Would celebrity editions work?

Celebrity participation could broaden audience reach and introduce the format to new viewers.

Charity-focused celebrity specials could allow celebrities to play for designated charitable prizes, while retaining the core tension of making consequential decisions about confidence and risk.

**Development Insight:** Celebrity and charity editions can explore different prize arrangements while preserving the essential experience: contestants must decide how much to risk on their answers.

### Could head-to-head competition work?

The standard format features two contestants playing separate, independent games. They do not compete directly against each other, and one contestant's results do not determine the other's prize.

A limited special event could explore direct competition, but that would be a variation on the standard format.

**Development Insight:** The defining strength of RISK vs. REWARD is individual decision-making under pressure. The standard format focuses on personal accountability and the consequences of each contestant's choices rather than a shared pot or a head-to-head contest.

## How would international adaptations work?

International versions could adjust prize structures, question content, language, and presentation styles to suit local markets while preserving the central gameplay.

The universal questions of knowledge, confidence, and decision-making provide a foundation for adaptations across different cultures and audiences.

**Development Insight:** The format's core mechanics are independent of any particular country's trivia categories or currency, allowing local versions to retain the essential experience while adapting to their markets.

## FINAL THOUGHT

At its core, RISK vs. REWARD is a test of how accurately contestants can measure their own confidence.

Knowledge determines whether they can answer the question. Confidence determines what they are willing to risk on that answer.

Everyone knows that answering correctly matters.

The real question is:

**How much would you bet you're right?**

## INTERACTIVE DEMO

Experience the format firsthand with a fully interactive prototype.

Players select categories, answer questions, and adjust their confidence using the RISK/REWARD Slider while watching potential outcomes update in real time.

Play the interactive demo: <https://eddielawhorn.com/risk-vs-reward/game>

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